



DELHI | Plotting a Course

The Prime Minister's Office has finally announced a list of 14 candidates for Sonia Gandhi's favourite think tank, the National Advisory Council (NAC). There are repeat appearances and then some more left-leaning policy wonks and even the odd chat show activist. Interestingly, no politician has made it to the list this time around. According to party sources, this is a planned move as the inclusion of a Congress leader in these ranks could be misinterpreted as his or her proximity to the Congress chief. This list marks the second coming of Sonia's favourite governance accessory and signals the UPA's commitment to social causes. Most of the UPA's trophy legislations were credited to the NAC—whether it was the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, the Domestic Violence Bill or the Right to Information Act. The NAC has been reconstituted at a time Sonia has become a more visible presence at the Government's control panels instead of working from the shadows at 10 Janpath. Not only did she push the Women's Reservations Bill through Parliament but even went on TV to claim credit for it. She sent the draft Food Security Bill back to the drawing board as it did not appear to match her level of social commitment. Although Prime Minister Manmohan Singh recently denied that this was a "super cabinet", that's exactly what the NAC really is.

SONIA HAS CHOSEN HER ADVISERS CAREFULLY THIS TIME

by Priya Sahgal

14

members, mostly social activists and left leaning liberals, have been nominated to Sonia's National Advisory Council. Not one politician figures on it.